We argue that based on the wider definition of balancing presented in the introduction to this volume, India is attempting to balance China. Nonetheless, this is a long-term effort. Based on our narrow definition of hard balancing, we conclude that India's response to China's rise currently falls short of hard balancing and that India is currently managing China's rise with hedging, although its policy is on the more conflictive side of hedging. We will here outline how we reached this conclusion. Finally, we further explore in which direction India's China policy is most likely headed over the next few years and discuss the challenges involved.

India's response to China's rise

In the introductory chapter to this volume, we presented a framework that enables us to locate India's response to China's rise on the spectrum of policies between balancing against China and bandwagoning with China. We introduced two interpretations of balancing – one wider definition of balancing that emphasises more long-term behaviour and intentions, where state behaviour is still compatible with hedging, and one narrow understanding of hard balancing in which state behaviour goes beyond that of hedging. Our framework also included the concept of hedging, defined as a strategy or policy that combines elements of both cooperation and confrontation simultaneously and which is consequently located in between balancing and bandwagoning. We divided hedging into three subtypes, conflictive hedging, extensive hedging, and cooperative hedging, to better understand nuances and in which direction India's policy on China is moving, towards more cooperation or more confrontation.